

Introduction to Ab Initio Nuclear Theory

Lecture 1: From one- to many-body correlations

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Everything is ab initio.
– Anonymous

1 What and why is ab initio?

What is ab initio? The term *ab initio* nuclear theory can be a controversial term. It was adopted in nuclear theory in the beginning of the century, borrowed from quantum chemistry, as a departure from the term *microscopic*. Generally it is used to refer to a family of model-independent approaches to solving the many-body Schrödinger's equation. Here model-independent means without uncontrolled approximations or assumptions that introduce unquantifiable errors. These approaches then hold the promise of results with robust errors and hence they hold the promise of predictive power with precision. Indeed, this endeavour has produced robust precise predictions or post-dictions of experimental measurements.

Why is ab initio? The purpose of ab initio nuclear theory is multi-faceted. Of course, the idea of a black machine that intakes a nuclear Hamiltonian and spits precise numbers is very attractive to non nuclear theorists, and ab initio methods are often set-up with that goal in mind. At the same time, when approaching nuclear theory as the material science of nucleons, ab initio nuclear theory wants to extract the properties of N nucleons solely from the properties of $n \ll N$ nucleons. Finally, and combining the two, when working on nuclear interactions, ab initio nuclear theory strives to connect the properties of N nucleons on the nuclear interaction in the Hamiltonian and from there to the underlying physics of QCD.

In these Lectures we will refer to ab initio nuclear theory as the attempt to solve the many-body Schrödinger's equation in a systematically improvable way: we will be looking for a knob that when turned all the way up we get an exact solution. Under this lens, we will refrain from referring to models but rather we'll focus on the underlying correlations present in the nuclear wavefunction instead.

2 Introduction to many body correlations

Our aim will be to solve the many-body Schrödinger's equation from first principles, that is, without any assumptions or uncontrolled approximations. We'll work both in first and second quantization of quantum mechanics so maybe the most appropriate point of departure is establishing these two languages for the many fermion problem and the connection between them

The wavefunction of N particles obeys the many-body Schrödinger's equation

$$i\hbar\partial_t\Psi(\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \dots, \mathbf{x}_N; t) = H\Psi(\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \dots, \mathbf{x}_N; t) . \quad (1)$$

As a rule we'll use lower case letters ($\psi, \phi, \dots$) for the wavefunctions of a single particle and capital letters ($\Psi, \Phi, \dots$) wavefunctions of many particles. The many-body Hamiltonian is *many-body* operator (see below for what exactly that means) and in coordinate space it takes the form

$$H = \sum_{i=1}^N T(\mathbf{x}_i) + \sum_{i<j}^N V_2(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j) + \sum_{i<j<k}^N V_3(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j, \mathbf{x}_k) + \dots , \quad (2)$$

where T is the kinetic energy operator (also to be specified clearly in a bit), and V_2, V_3 , etc., are two-, three-, etc., particle potentials. Contrary to many introduction to many-particle quantum mechanics in condensed matter theory, here we explicitly allow for many-particle forces. As we will see in Lecture 3, this is an essential element in the accurate description of many-nucleon systems.

The many-body wavefunction $\Psi(\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \dots, \mathbf{x}_N)$ is a function of $d \times N$ coordinates and identifying (or inferring) its exact form is a central aim of *ab initio* nuclear theory. As with every-multivariate function we can expand the many-body wavefunction in sums of products of a complete set of functions that depend on fewer variables (as long as they provide the same asymptotic behaviours). As the simplest choice, we can choose a complete set of single-particle wavefunctions which will allow us an interpretation of each term in the sum as a configuration of particles in individual single-particle states. So we make a choice of a complete set $\{\phi_E(\mathbf{x})\}$ spanned by all possible values of E which stands for the necessary set of quantum numbers (e.g., $\mathbf{k}, s_z$ for fermions in a box) and the wavefunction becomes

$$\Psi(\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \dots, \mathbf{x}_N; t) = \sum_{E_1 E_2 \dots E_N} C(E_1, E_2, \dots, E_N; t) \phi_{E_1}(\mathbf{x}_1) \phi_{E_2}(\mathbf{x}_2) \dots \phi_{E_N}(\mathbf{x}_N) . \quad (3)$$

Note that now the time-dependence is prescribed by the expansion coefficients C and that the wavefunction's normalization carries over to C as

$$\int d^d x_1 d^d x_2 \dots d^d x_N |\Psi(\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \dots, \mathbf{x}_N; t)|^2 = \sum_{E_1 E_2 \dots E_N} |C(E_1, E_2, \dots, E_N)|^2 = 1 \quad (4)$$

The wavefunctions of the type in each term in Eq. (3)'s RHS are also sometimes called *Hartree products* in quantum chemistry, because they are a product of single-particle orbitals, and in these states the probability density of finding particles $1, 2, \dots, N$ within volume elements $d\mathbf{x}_1, d\mathbf{x}_2, \dots, d\mathbf{x}_N$ centered at positions $\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \dots, \mathbf{x}_N$, is a product of probabilities,

$$|\phi_{E_1}(\mathbf{x}_1)|^2 d\mathbf{x}_1 |\phi_{E_2}(\mathbf{x}_2)|^2 d\mathbf{x}_2 \dots |\phi_{E_N}(\mathbf{x}_N)|^2 d\mathbf{x}_N \quad (5)$$

Of course, the choice of $\{\phi_E(\mathbf{x})\}$ is far from unique and that is a good thing: any complete set of single-particle states will do, but some will do better than others. The number of terms in Eq. (3) depends heavily on the choice of the single-particle states used. A sum of many terms is harder to interpret than a sum of few, even when a single coordinate is involved, e.g., $\sum_{n=1}^{1000} (-1)^n x^{2n+1} / (2n+1)!$ has an approximate period of 2π , but that's hard to tell by inspection. Even before any attempts for interpretation, the number of terms in Eq. (3) will determine if such an approach is even practical for calculations. As such one would like to choose the set of single-particle orbitals wisely, to reduce the number of terms entering Eq. (3) and provide practical methods. Finding the expansion coefficients C would mean having the many-body wavefunction, but doing this in a brute force is hopeless. To see this explicitly we can attempt it and plug Eq. (3) into the many-body Schrödinger's equation in Eq. (1) and projecting on one set of quantum numbers (multiplying with the hermitian and integrating of all $\mathbf{x}$'s) yielding

$$\begin{aligned} i\hbar \partial_t C(E_1, E_2, \dots, E_N; t) &= \sum_{i=1}^N \sum_W \left[\int d^d x_i \phi_{E_i}^\dagger(x_i) T(x_i) \phi_W(x_i) \right] C(E_1, \dots, E_{i-1}, W, E_{i+1}, \dots, E_N; t) \\ &+ \sum_{i < j} \sum_{WW'} \left[\int d^d x_i d^d x_j \phi_{E_i}^\dagger(x_i) \phi_{E_j}^\dagger(x_j) V_2(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j) \phi_W(x_i) \phi_{W'}(\mathbf{x}_j) \right] C(E_1, \dots, E_{i-1}, W, E_{i+1}, \dots, E_{j-1}, W', E_{j+1}, \dots, E_N; t) \\ &+ \sum_{i < j < k} \sum_{WW'W''} \left[\int d^d x_i d^d x_j d^d x_k \phi_{E_i}^\dagger(x_i) \phi_{E_j}^\dagger(x_j) \phi_{E_k}^\dagger(x_k) V_3(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j) \phi_W(x_i) \phi_{W'}(\mathbf{x}_j) \phi_{W''}(\mathbf{x}_k) \right] \times \\ &\times C(E_1, \dots, E_{i-1}, W, E_{i+1}, \dots, E_{j-1}, W', E_{j+1}, \dots, E_{k-1}, W'', E_{k+1}, \dots, E_N; t) . \end{aligned} \quad (6)$$

For each set of quantum numbers $\{E_1, \dots, E_N\}$, Eq. (6) yields a set of differential equations. Even when truncated, this approach is hopeless for most practical cases.

Note that up to this point we haven't mentioned anything about the particles' statistics, that is, the terms in the sum in Eq. (3) have some symmetries stemming from the indistinguishability of quantum particles. For fermions

this manifests as a property of the wavefunction

$$\Psi(\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \dots, \mathbf{x}_i, \dots, \mathbf{x}_j, \mathbf{x}_N; t) = -\Psi(\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \dots, \mathbf{x}_j, \dots, \mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_N; t) , \quad (7)$$

where for bosons RHS's sign would be positive. This property transfers to the expansion coefficients C as

$$C(E_1, E_2, \dots, E_i, \dots, E_j, E_N; t) = -C(E_1, E_2, \dots, E_j, \dots, E_i, E_N; t) . \quad (8)$$

From this the Pauli exclusion principle follows which states that if two quantum numbers are the same, e.g., $E_1 = E_2$, then C vanishes. That is, in each configuration that describes the many-body wavefunction, no two particles can be in the same state. As we'll see later this introduces the lowest rank of correlations to the system because each particle knows some information about what other particles are doing. More importantly the indistinguishability of particles also allows for a more convenient description in terms of occupation numbers, that is, we can describe each configuration by the number of particles that occupy each state in the set $\{E\}$. Forgetting for the moment that only one fermion at a time can occupy state each E , we can define the coefficients

$$\bar{C}(n_1, n_2, \dots, n_\infty) = C(E_1, E_1, \dots, E_2, E_2, \dots, E_2, \dots) , \quad (9)$$

Note that a single permutation of the arguments of C on the LHS would just introduce a minus sign. We could now parse all terms in Eq. (3) and replace all instances of $C(E_1, E_1, \dots, E_2, E_2, \dots, E_2, \dots)$ and its permutations multiplied by the appropriate minus signs. We would be making $N!/n_1!n_2!\dots n_\infty!$ replacements of a C coefficient with the *same* $\bar{C}$ coefficient times a sign. This means that in Eq. (4), every $N!/n_1!n_2!\dots n_\infty!$ terms will be the same:

$$1 = \sum_{E_1 E_2 \dots E_N} |C(E_1, E_2, \dots, E_N)|^2 = \sum_{n_1 n_2 \dots n_\infty} |\bar{C}(n_1, n_2, \dots, n_\infty)|^2 \frac{N!}{n_1!n_2!\dots n_\infty!} \quad (10)$$

This tells of a symmetry which we have already specified: the wavefunction is fully antisymmetric under the exchange of particles. To exploit this symmetry we define two things. First, we define the coefficients f

$$f(n_1, n_2, \dots, n_\infty) = \left(\frac{N!}{n_1!n_2!\dots n_\infty!} \right)^{\frac{1}{2}} \bar{C}(n_1, n_2, \dots, n_\infty) \quad (11)$$

such that $\sum_{n_1 \dots n_\infty} |f(n_1, \dots, n_\infty)|^2 = 1$. Second, we examine each replacement we made realizing that a minus sign was introduced only when the C coefficient that was replaced was an odd permutation of particle indices away from the one in Eq. (9). This means that if we group all terms that correspond to a set of occupation numbers $n_1, n_2, \dots, n_\infty$, we can define a many-particle wavefunction

$$\Phi_{n_1 n_2 \dots n_\infty}(\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \dots, \mathbf{x}_N) = \left(\frac{n_1!n_2!\dots n_\infty!}{N!} \right)^{\frac{1}{2}} \sum_{\sigma \in \mathcal{P}_N} (-1)^\sigma \phi_{E_1}(\mathbf{x}_\sigma(1)) \phi_{E_2}(\mathbf{x}_\sigma(2)) \dots \phi_{E_N}(\mathbf{x}_\sigma(N)) \quad (12)$$

$$= \left(\frac{n_1!n_2!\dots n_\infty!}{N!} \right)^{\frac{1}{2}} \begin{vmatrix} \phi_{E_1}(\mathbf{x}_1) & \phi_{E_1}(\mathbf{x}_2) & \dots & \phi_{E_1}(\mathbf{x}_N) \\ \phi_{E_2}(\mathbf{x}_1) & \phi_{E_2}(\mathbf{x}_2) & \dots & \phi_{E_2}(\mathbf{x}_N) \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ \phi_{E_N}(\mathbf{x}_1) & \phi_{E_N}(\mathbf{x}_2) & \dots & \phi_{E_N}(\mathbf{x}_N) \end{vmatrix} , \quad (13)$$

where we have introduced the inverse of the combinatorics factor we discussed before for later convenience, σ is any permutation in the permutation group $\mathcal{P}_N$ that contains all permutations of N objects and $(-1)^\sigma$ is positive (negative) for even (odd) permutations. For the second line of Eq. (13), we recognized the definition of a determinant. This object is called a *Slater determinant* and we'll list its properties further below. For now we'll only note that

they are a complete basis of antisymmetric functions of many-variables. Putting all definitions together, we can finally write Eq. (3) in terms of the occupation numbers,

$$\Psi(\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \dots, \mathbf{x}_N) = \sum_{n_1 n_2 \dots n_\infty}^1 f(n_1, n_2, \dots, n_\infty) \Phi_{n_1, n_2, \dots, n_\infty}(\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \dots, \mathbf{x}_N) . \quad (14)$$

This is the form of the wavefunction in second quantization where we use occupation numbers instead of sets of quantum numbers and each term in the expansion is explicitly antisymmetric.

In order to take full advantage of the simplification that second quantization has to offer, one also defines the state vector

$$|n_1 n_2 \dots n_\infty\rangle \quad (15)$$

such that

$$\langle \mathbf{x}_1 \mathbf{x}_2 \dots \mathbf{x}_N | n_1 n_2 \dots n_\infty \rangle = \Phi_{n_1 n_2 \dots n_\infty}(\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \dots, \mathbf{x}_N) \quad (16)$$

and corresponding creation and annihilation operators, $a_i, a_i^\dagger$ such that

$$a_i^\dagger |n_1 n_2 \dots n_i \dots n_\infty\rangle = \sqrt{n_i + 1} |n_1 n_2 \dots n_i + 1 \dots n_\infty\rangle , \quad (17)$$

$$a_i |n_1 n_2 \dots n_i \dots n_\infty\rangle = \sqrt{n_i} |n_1 n_2 \dots n_i - 1 \dots n_\infty\rangle , \quad (18)$$

which obey the *anti-commutation* relations

$$\{a_i, a_j\} = 0 \quad (19)$$

$$\{a_i, a_j^\dagger\} = \delta_{ij} . \quad (20)$$

Note that this means that the creation and annihilation operators carry with them (in their algebra) the commutation relation such that one doesn't have to worry about them. Further, $\langle \mathbf{x} | a_i^\dagger | 0 \rangle = \phi_i(\mathbf{x})$, that is, each creation or annihilation operator carries with it a single-particle wavefunction. One then finds that each state vector can be constructed as

$$\left(a_1^\dagger\right)^{n_1} \left(a_2^\dagger\right)^{n_2} \dots \left(a_\infty^\dagger\right)^{n_\infty} |0\rangle = \prod_{i=1}^{\infty} \left(a_i^\dagger\right)^{n_i} |0\rangle = |n_1 n_2 \dots n_\infty\rangle , \quad (21)$$

where

$$|0\rangle = |00 \dots 0\rangle \quad (22)$$

is the vacuum state. Putting all these definitions together and with some manipulation one arrives at the second quantized version of the Hamiltonian

$$H = \sum_{ij} \langle i | T | j \rangle a_i^\dagger a_j + \frac{1}{2} \sum_{ijkl} \langle ij | V_2 | kl \rangle a_i^\dagger a_j^\dagger a_l a_k + \frac{1}{3!} \sum_{ijklmn} \langle ijk | V_3 | lmn \rangle a_i^\dagger a_j^\dagger a_k^\dagger a_n a_m a_l + \dots \quad (23)$$

where note the reverse ordering of the annihilation operators. We have come full circle back to the many-body Hamiltonian but now in second quantization. This definition can be extended now to any other operator *n-body* operator A

$$A(\mathbf{x}_1, \mathbf{x}_2, \dots, \mathbf{x}_N) = \sum_{i_1 \neq i_2 \neq \dots i_N=1}^N A(\mathbf{x}_{i_1}, \mathbf{x}_{i_2}, \dots, \mathbf{x}_{i_N}) = \sum_{\substack{k_1 k_2 \dots k_N \\ l_1 l_2 \dots l_N}} \langle k_1 k_2 \dots k_N | A | l_1 l_2 \dots l_N \rangle a_{k_1}^\dagger a_{k_2}^\dagger \dots a_{k_N}^\dagger a_{l_n} \dots a_{l_2} a_{l_1} , \quad (24)$$

where now the definition of a n -body operator is clear: when acting on a state $|n_1 n_2 \dots n_\infty\rangle$ it redistributes n occupation numbers.

2.1 Recasting Schrodinger's Equation: the Rayleigh-Ritz principle

2.1.1 The general formulation

At the heart of many ab initio techniques lies the fact that the expectation value of the Hamiltonian at *any* trial state ψ_T is an upper bound to the ground state. This is a general result that holds for any ψ_T , but, of course, its practical value is seen when ψ_T is chosen “close” to the ground state and its energy becomes a tight bound on the ground state energy. What is meant by “close” here will be quantified in this section to mean “large overlap in Hilbert space”. Furthermore, we will validate the assumption that the “closer” a trial state is to the ground state, the tighter the energy bound.

First we define the basis spanned by eigenstates of the many-body Hamiltonian in Eq. (??), $|\Phi_n\rangle$, that is,

$$H |\Phi_n\rangle = E_n |\Phi_n\rangle .$$

Even though we don't know much about $|\Phi_n\rangle$ (after all our goal here is to acquire access to $|\Phi_0\rangle$, or at least E_0), we will use that their eigenstates of H , their orthonormality, $\langle\Phi_n|\Phi_m\rangle = \delta_{nm}$ and their completeness, i.e., that they form a basis, for a proof. Our trial state can be expressed as

$$|\Psi_T\rangle = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} a_n |\Phi_n\rangle , \quad \text{with } a_n = \langle\Phi_n|\Psi_T\rangle \quad (25)$$

Note that we don't assume that $|\Psi_T\rangle$ is normalized. The so-called variational energy E_V is just the normalized expectation value of the Hamiltonian at $|\Psi_T\rangle$,

$$E_V = \frac{\langle\Psi_T|H|\Psi_T\rangle}{\langle\Psi_T|\Psi_T\rangle} = \frac{\sum_{n',n} a_{n'}^* a_n \langle\Phi_{n'}|H|\Phi_n\rangle}{\sum_{n',n} a_{n'}^* a_n \langle\Phi_{n'}|\Phi_n\rangle} = \frac{\sum_n |a_n|^2 E_n}{\sum_n |a_n|^2} = E_0 + \frac{\sum_n |a_n|^2 (E_n - E_0)}{\sum_n |a_n|^2} \geq E_0 \quad (26)$$

where to prove the bound we have used that $E_0 < E_n$ for every n . This result also allows us to use the variational energy to quantify when a state is “close” to the ground state. To see this more concretely, let's consider our trial state to be normalized $\langle\Psi_T|\Psi_T\rangle = 1$, or $\sum_n |a_n|^2 = 1$ (equivalently we could define $\tilde{a}_n = a_n / \sqrt{\sum_n |a_n|^2}$), such that the bound we just proved becomes

$$E_V = E_0 + \sum_n |\tilde{a}_n|^2 (E_n - E_0) \quad (27)$$

We will show that a small variation away from the ground state translates to a small shift in energy. Indeed, if our trial state is almost equal to the ground state, with only a small admixture of a state $|\Phi_1\rangle$, then $a_1 = \eta$, $a_0 = \sqrt{1 - \eta^2}$, and $a_n = 0$ otherwise, where we are implying that η is a small number. This means,

$$|\Psi_T\rangle = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} a_n |\Phi_n\rangle = \sqrt{1 - \eta^2} |\Phi_0\rangle + \eta |\Phi_1\rangle \quad (28)$$

and the bound becomes

$$E_V = E_0 + \sum_n |a_n|^2 (E_n - E_0) = E_0 + \eta^2 (E_1 - E_0) \quad (29)$$

In words, as the excited-state components of the trial state decrease *linearly* the variational energy approaches the ground state energy *quadratically*. So, the variational energy can quantify the distance of the trial state from the ground state. As we will see in Lecture 5 on Quantum Monte Carlo, this provides the motivation behind variational methods like Variational Monte Carlo: stepping through a Hilbert space in a direction that decreases the variational

energy is a path that leads to the ground state. If one parametrizes such a walk with a set of parameters α_i , such that $|\Psi_T(\alpha_i)\rangle$ is a state along this walk, finding the best approximation to the ground state is reduced to a standard *multi-dimensional* minimization problem that involves minimizing the function

$$E_V(\alpha) = \frac{\langle \Psi_T(\alpha) | H | \Psi_T(\alpha) \rangle}{\langle \Psi_T(\alpha) | \Psi_T(\alpha) \rangle} \quad (30)$$

with respect to the parameters α . Of course, evaluating such integrals is a hard task and the success of VMC lies in its efficiency to evaluate them integrals using Monte Carlo techniques.

2.1.2 The variational principle for excited states

An important caveat to the above proof is that E_V is an *upper bound to the lowest eigenvalue whose eigenstate is not orthogonal to $|\Psi_T\rangle$* . This should be straightforward to see from Eq. (26) where if $|\Psi_T\rangle$ were orthogonal to $|\Phi_0\rangle$ then E_0 would be absent because it would be $a_0 = 0$. In that case we would get a bound for E_1 (similarly, if $\langle \Psi_T | \Phi_1 \rangle \neq 0$. In the case where $|\Psi_T\rangle$ depends on variational parameters α , then the bound holds if for there is α_0 such that $\langle \Psi_T(\alpha_0) | \Phi_0 \rangle \neq 0$. Of course this hold in principle, in practice it's better if there is a finite (and preferably large) region in the α -space in which $|\Psi_T\rangle$ is not orthogonal to $|\Phi_0\rangle$. This is because in practice one needs to survey (at least some part of) the space of possible α 's to identify the minimum: isolate minima are hard to identify. This is where physical intuition is needed to identify the expected symmetries of the ground state and ensure that the trial state chosen has components that posses those symmetries.

While this caveat can be a nuisance when looking for the ground state, one can take advantage of it to use the variational principle to provide an upper bound for excited states of the Hamiltonian. This is done when by some physical principle we are certain of some symmetry of the ground state. Then we can construct a trial state $|\Psi_T\rangle$ that has no components with this symmetry guaranteeing that $\langle \Psi_T | \Phi_0 \rangle = 0$

Note that for this to work then it should be $\langle \Psi(\alpha) | \Phi_0 \rangle = 0$ for all possible values of α . This might sound trivial but we'll see in the example below how it can become a subtle point.

We will see this play out clearly in the example below.

2.1.3 Intuitive example from matrix diagonalization

In the above proof we have employed no physical argument and so the variational principle should hold for any matrix diagonalization: given a matrix O and a vector $\mathbf{v}$, the number $\mathbf{v}^\dagger O \mathbf{v} / \mathbf{v}^\dagger \cdot \mathbf{v}$ is greater or equal to the lowest eigenvalue of O that is not orthogonal to $\mathbf{v}$. We'll see this for the special case of a symmetric 2×2 matrix.

Consider the symmetric matrix

$$O = \begin{pmatrix} O_{11} & O_{12} \\ O_{21} & O_{22} \end{pmatrix}, \quad (31)$$

with $O_{12} = O_{21}$. The diagonalization of this matrix is trivial and so we will use it as an example to get an insight on how the variational principle works. First we will diagonalize O by identifying the unitary transformation that makes it diagonal and then apply the variational principle to get an upper bound to the lowest eigenvalue. By doing so we'll see that if by some other considerations one knows enough about the symmetries of the lowest eigenvalue's vector, the variational principle can be invoked to identify it *exactly*. Let U be the unitary matrix that diagonalizes O , that is,

$$U^\dagger O U = \begin{pmatrix} \omega_1 & 0 \\ 0 & \omega_2 \end{pmatrix}, \quad (32)$$

where ω_i are the eigenvalues of O . The requirement for U to be unitary provides three constraints for the elements of U :

$$U^\dagger U = \begin{pmatrix} U_{11}U_{11} + U_{21}U_{21} & U_{11}U_{12} + U_{21}U_{22} \\ U_{11}U_{12} + U_{21}U_{22} & U_{12}U_{12} + U_{22}U_{22} \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \implies \begin{array}{l} U_{11}^2 + U_{21}^2 = 1 \\ U_{11}U_{12} + U_{21}U_{22} = 0 \\ U_{12}^2 + U_{22}^2 = 1 \end{array} \quad (33)$$

This means that U is described by a single parameter. It's then convenient to write U in terms of a parameter θ as

$$U(\theta) = \begin{pmatrix} \cos \theta & \sin \theta \\ \sin \theta & -\cos \theta \end{pmatrix} \quad (34)$$

which satisfies all constraints and it's the most general form of an orthogonal matrix. Then it is

$$U^\dagger O U = \begin{pmatrix} O_{11} \cos^2 \theta + O_{22} \sin^2 \theta + O_{12} \sin 2\theta & \frac{1}{2}(O_{11} - O_{22}) \sin 2\theta - O_{12} \cos 2\theta \\ \frac{1}{2}(O_{11} - O_{22}) \sin 2\theta - O_{12} \cos 2\theta & O_{11} \cos^2 \theta + O_{22} \sin^2 \theta - O_{12} \sin 2\theta \end{pmatrix} \quad (35)$$

We can now choose $\theta = \theta_0$ such that this matrix becomes diagonal, that is, its off-diagonal elements, which are both the same, vanish, or

$$\frac{1}{2}(O_{11} - O_{22}) \sin 2\theta_0 - O_{12} \cos 2\theta_0 = 0. \quad (36)$$

Then we can read the eigenvalues from the diagonal elements,

$$\omega_{\frac{1}{2}} = O_{11} \cos^2 \theta + O_{22} \sin^2 \theta \pm O_{12} \sin 2\theta \quad (37)$$

Note that this reproduces the known behaviour of the bifurcation of eigenvalues of a 2×2 symmetric matrix. The solution of Eq. (36),

$$\theta_0 = \frac{1}{2} \arctan \left(\frac{2O_{12}}{O_{11} - O_{22}} \right) \quad (38)$$

Further, we know that the columns of the transformation matrix U correspond to the eigenvectors and so

$$\mathbf{v}_1 = (\cos \theta_0, \sin \theta_0)^T, \quad \mathbf{v}_2 = (\sin \theta_0, -\cos \theta_0)^T, \quad (39)$$

and the diagonalization of O is done. Note that $\mathbf{v}_1 \cdot \mathbf{v}_2 = 0$, as expected for the eigenvectors of a Hermitian matrix.

We will now pretend that we don't know the eigenvalues of O and apply the variational principle to get an upper bound to the lowest one. We choose for our $\mathbf{v}_T$ the normalized vector

$$\mathbf{v}(\phi) = (\cos \phi, \sin \phi)^T. \quad (40)$$

Then we calculate

$$\omega(\phi) = \frac{\mathbf{v}(\phi)^\dagger O \mathbf{v}(\phi)}{\mathbf{v}(\phi)^\dagger \cdot \mathbf{v}(\phi)} = \sin^2(\phi) O_{11} - 2 \cos(\phi) \sin(\phi) O_{12} + \cos^2(\phi) O_{12} \quad (41)$$

$$= \sin^2(\phi) O_{11} + \sin(2\phi) O_{12} + \cos^2(\phi) O_{12} \quad (42)$$

We can now minimize this function of a single variable by finding the roots of its derivative

$$\omega'(\phi) = 2 \cos(2\phi) O_{12} - 2 \cos(\phi) \sin(\phi) (O_{11} - O_{22}) \quad (43)$$

and solving for the root ϕ_0 gives

$$\omega'(\phi_0) = 0 \implies \phi_0 = \frac{1}{2} \arctan \left(\frac{2O_{12}}{O_{11} - O_{22}} \right) = \theta_0 \quad (44)$$

That is we found the special case where the equal sign holds in Eq. (26). Now $\omega(\phi_0)$ is the lowest eigenvalue and $\mathbf{v}(\phi_0)$ is the best approximation of the corresponding eigenstate, which in this case is the eigenstate itself.

Given the above discussion now one might be tempted to use $\tilde{\mathbf{v}}(\phi) = (\sin \phi, -\cos \phi)$ to get the other eigenvalue since

$$\tilde{\mathbf{v}}^\dagger(\phi) \cdot \mathbf{v}(\phi) = 0 \quad (45)$$

for every ϕ . However, this would lead to the same ϕ_0 . This is because

$$\tilde{\mathbf{v}}^\dagger(\phi) \cdot \mathbf{v}_1(\theta_0) = \sin(\phi) \cos(\theta_0) - \cos(\phi) \sin(\theta_0) \quad (46)$$

which is 0 only for $\phi = \theta_0$.

3 The Hartree-Fock state: getting the most out of a single Slater Determinant

In the previous section we saw how the Slater Determinant can act as a basis for the many-body wavefunction. Here we will see how far a single element of that basis can take us when trying to describe the ground-state of a system. That is we will formulate the method that provides the Slater Determinant (SD) with the lowest energy. This is the Hartree-Fock(HF) method.

When applying the HF method to the ground state, one attempts to identify the SD with the lowest energy. Since the SD uniquely defines the structure of the state, what is left to be identified are the single-particle states that compose it (see Eq. (13). In other words, one needs to identify an appropriate single-particle basis; we will use the letter ϕ to symbolize the entire basis. (The choice of words here is not accidental: as it turns out, the basis ϕ is often considered ideal for building a multiple SD description after the fact.) As such, we are looking for the state $|\text{HF}(\phi)\rangle$ such that

$$E_{\text{HF}(\phi)} = \langle \text{HF}(\phi) | H | \text{HF}(\phi) \rangle, \quad (47)$$

with

$$|\text{HF}(\phi)\rangle = \prod_{i=1}^N a_i^\dagger |0\rangle, \quad \text{with} \quad \langle \mathbf{x} | a_i^\dagger |0\rangle = \phi_i(\mathbf{x}). \quad (48)$$

Here we assumed an ordering of the basis ϕ such that the first N states are occupied in the HF state. These states we will call *hole states* as they can only be occupied by holes, which are, by definition the absence of particles. The states with $i > N$ we will call *particle states* as they can only be occupied by particles. Somewhat confusingly, in the HF state, the particle (hole) states are completely occupied by holes (particles) (and so they are unoccupied by particles (holes)).

Formulating the problem this way might make one suspect that it could be recast as a single-particle problem. This is mostly the case, as what we are after are single particle orbitals. However, for the SD to minimize the many-particle Hamiltonian, each single-particle orbital must have some information about the state of the other particles. In the previous section we showed how an SD arises as the description of a many-particle system where

each particle moves in a predefined orbital, not explicitly of the existence of other particles (e.g., the orbital $\phi_1(\mathbf{x})$ take in the coordinates of only one particle). Hence, in our problem the information about the other particles must come from the definition of the orbitals. We will seek to construct these orbitals, i.e., single-particle basis, as the eigenfunctions of an one-body operator h (this guarantees orthogonality and the orbitals will be a basis):

$$h(\mathbf{x})\phi_i(\mathbf{x}) = \epsilon_i\phi_i(\mathbf{x}) . \quad (49)$$

As we saw in the previous section, a one-body operator (that now acts on the *many-body* wavefunction) can be constructed from h as,

$$H_{\text{HF}} = \sum_{i=1}^N h(\mathbf{x}_i) . \quad (50)$$

As the subscript suggests, this one-body operator uniquely defines the HF state and it often goes by the name of *Hartree-Fock potential*. The problem is now recast as almost a single-particle one: we need to find h and its connection to the full many-body Hamiltonian H . The plan now is the following: we will express the energy $E_{\text{HF}}(\phi)$ in Eq. (47) in a convenient formulation and we will show how its minimization over all possible bases ϕ defines h from the many-body Hamiltonian H .

The efficient formulation mentioned above is the one of the density matrices which we will briefly define now. Our basis ϕ is unknown, however, we can express it in terms of a known basis χ as

$$\phi_i = \sum_j D_{ji} \chi_j . \quad (51)$$

where D is a unitary transformation that connects on complete and orthogonal basis to the other and so $DD^\dagger = 1$. We can associate the basis χ with a set of creation (annihilation) operators $c_i^\dagger(c_i)$, in the sense that $|\mathbf{x}\rangle c_i^\dagger |0\rangle = \chi_i(\mathbf{x})$ leading to the relation between operators

$$a_i^\dagger = \sum_j D_{ji} c_j^\dagger . \quad (52)$$

The density matrix of the HF state on the basis ϕ is defined a

$$\rho_{ij} = \langle \text{HF}(\phi) | a_j^\dagger a_i | \text{HF}(\phi) \rangle = \delta_{ij} \theta(N - i) , \quad (53)$$

that is, the density matrix of a SD on its own single-particle basis is diagonal with 1's for $i \leq N$ and 0's for $i > N$. This is an alternative definition of a SD. Because of this, diagonalizing a density matrix cannot provide much information about the unoccupied states which have eigenvalue 0. Furthermore, any unitary transformation that doesn't mix occupied ($i \leq N$) states and unoccupied ones ($i > N$) leaves the corresponding SD unchanged (up to an overall phase). A consequence of Eq. (53) is that $\text{Tr}\rho = N$. Another consequence of Eq. (53) is that for a SD, $\rho^2 = \rho$. This is another definition of a SD.

One can then define the density matrix of the HF state, i.e., the SD composed of the basis ϕ , on the basis χ ,

$$\rho_{ij} = \langle \text{HF}(\phi) | c_j^\dagger c_i | \text{HF}(\phi) \rangle = \sum_{kl} D_{ik} D_{jl}^* \langle \text{HF}(\phi) | a_k^\dagger a_l | \text{HF}(\phi) \rangle = \sum_k D_{ik} D_{jk}^* . \quad (54)$$

We can now slightly reformulate the problem: we seek the state with density matrix ρ that yields minimum energy (this refers to the full many-body Hamiltonian H) in the set of states with

$$\text{Tr}\rho = N \quad \text{and} \quad \rho^2 = \rho . \quad (55)$$

We will now express E_{MF} using the HF state's density matrix and demand that it minimizes it by requiring that any small variation in ρ should increase the energy.

We will restrict ourselves to two-body forces but it should be straightforward how any of these expressions generalizes to higher-body forces. Our Hamiltonian are the first two terms in Eq. (2), which we write in the χ basis (i.e., exchanging a 's for c 's)

$$H = \sum_{ij} t_{ij} c_i^\dagger c_j + \frac{1}{4} \sum_{ijkl} \bar{v}_{ij,kl} c_i^\dagger c_j^\dagger c_l c_k \quad (56)$$

where we have used the shorthand $t_{ij} = \langle i | T | j \rangle$ and we have also taken advantage of the antisymmetry of the two-particle wavefunctions, as is very often done, and written the potential matrix elements as

$$\bar{v}_{ij,kl} = v_{ijkl} - v_{ijlk} . \quad (57)$$

Deriving the form of E_{HF} in Eq. (47) in terms of the density matrix is an exercise in Wick's theorem and it yields

$$E_{\text{HF}}(\phi) = \sum_{ij} t_{ij} \rho_{ij}(\phi) + \frac{1}{2} \sum_{ijkl} \bar{v}_{ij,kl} \rho_{ki}(\phi) \rho_{lj}(\phi) = \text{Tr}[t\rho(\phi)] + \frac{1}{2} \text{Tr}_1 \text{Tr}_1 [\rho(\phi) \bar{v} \rho(\phi)] . \quad (58)$$

where Tr_1 is an obvious shorthand notation. Following the plan we'll now investigate what a small variation in ρ does to $E_{\text{HF}}[\rho]$. Following the calculus of variations, changing ρ by $\delta\rho$ into $\rho' = \rho + \delta\rho$ results in a change in δE_{HF} in E_{HF} ,

$$\delta E_{\text{HF}} = E_{\text{HF}}[\rho] - E_{\text{HF}}[\rho - \delta\rho] = \sum_{ij} \frac{\partial E_{\text{HF}}[\rho]}{\partial \rho_{ij}} \delta \rho_{ij} , \quad (59)$$

where we've only kept terms linear in $\delta\rho$. We would like δE_{HF} to vanish for any variation in ρ (up to the constraints in Eq. (55), but we will ignore this for now, keep the variation general and address this constraint below.) As it turns out the single-particle Hamiltonian we were looking for in Eq. (49) is $h_{ij} = \partial E_{\text{HF}}[\rho] / \partial \rho_{ij}$ and from Eq. (58) we get

$$h_{ij} = \partial E_{\text{HF}}[\rho] / \partial \rho_{ij} = t_{ij} + \Gamma_{ij} , \quad (60)$$

where

$$\Gamma_{ij} = \sum_{kl} \bar{v}_{il,jk} \rho_{kl} , \quad (61)$$

is the so-called *Fock operator*. At this point we'll have to consider the constraints of Eq. (55) and especially the second one (the first one is relatively simple to enforce in practice.): the variations in ρ should happen such that ρ remains the density matrix of a SD, or equivalently,

$$(\rho + \delta\rho)^2 = \rho + \delta\rho \quad (62)$$

and keeping up to linear terms in $\delta\rho$,

$$\delta\rho = \rho\delta\rho + \delta\rho\rho \quad (63)$$

In the HF basis, where ρ is diagonal and acts a projector on the occupied states (because its 0 anywhere else) this means that

$$\rho\delta\rho\rho = 0 = (1 - \rho)\delta\rho(1 - \rho) \quad (64)$$

or in words, to make sure that we are considering variations within the subset of many-particle states that are SDs, we must only make variations that don't change the particle-particle ($pp; \rho_{ij}$, with $i, j \leq N$) and hole-hole ($hh; \rho_{ij}$, with $i, j > N$) parts of the density matrix, in the HF-basis. That is, in the HF basis, we can only allow for variations of the particle-hole (ph) or hole-particle (ph) parts of the density matrix, which provides the constraint

$$[h, \rho] = 0 \quad (65)$$

for $h = t + \Gamma$. Note one could start from Eq. (65) immediately as it dictates that h from Eq. (60) and ρ should be simultaneously diagonalizable which means that ρ is an SD made of the eigenfunctions of h . In more detail, since the diagonalization of ρ is determined up to a unitary transformation within particle states or hole states, we can choose this transformation to be the one that diagonalizes h and so we are left with an eigenproblem of h ,

$$hD = \epsilon D \quad (66)$$

$$\sum_k h_{ik} D_{kj} = \sum_k \left(t_{ij} + \sum_{l=1}^N \sum_{pr} \bar{v}_{ir, kp} D_{pl} D_{ri}^* \right) D_{kj} = \epsilon_j D_{ij} . \quad (67)$$

This equation determines D which determines ϕ via Eq. (51). We are now done: we have derived a one-body Hamiltonian,

$$H_{\text{HF}} = \sum_{i=1}^N h(\mathbf{x}_i) = \sum_{ij} h_{ij} c_i^\dagger c_j = \sum_i \epsilon_i a_i^\dagger a_i , \quad (68)$$

where ϵ_i is often called the Hartree-Fock spectrum. The ground state of this Hamiltonian is the HF state, a SD composed of the N lowest eigenfunctions of h which yields the minimum energy for the full many-body Hamiltonian of all other SD states. The Hartree-Fock energy, that is, the energy of the full many-body Hamiltonian at the Hartree-Fock state is then

$$E_{\text{HF}} = \sum_{i=1}^N \epsilon_i - \frac{1}{2} \sum_{ij=1}^N \bar{v}_{ij, ij} . \quad (69)$$

Before we finish, let's see explicitly why Hartree-Fock is a mean-field method. If we write Eq. (67) in coordinate space we get

$$\left(-\frac{\hbar^2}{2m} \nabla^2 + \Gamma_H(\mathbf{x}) \right) \phi_k(\mathbf{x}) + \int d\mathbf{x}' \Gamma_F(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') \phi(\mathbf{x}') = \epsilon_k \phi_k(\mathbf{x}) \quad (70)$$

where

$$\Gamma_H(\mathbf{x}) = \int d\mathbf{x}' v(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') \rho(\mathbf{x}') \quad (71)$$

$$\Gamma_F(\mathbf{x}) = -v(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') \rho(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{x}') \quad (72)$$